CHAPTER 8

Fallible: The Network Is Often Wrong

In *The Gulag Archipelago* (1973), Aleksandr Solzhenitsyn chronicles the history of the Soviet labour camps and of the information network that created and sustained them. He was writing partly from bitter personal experience. When Solzhenitsyn served as a captain in the Red Army during the Second World War, he maintained a private correspondence with a school friend in which he occasionally criticised Stalin. To be on the safe side, he did not mention the dictator by name and spoke only about 'the man with the moustache'. It availed him little. His letters were intercepted and read by the secret police, and in February 1945, while serving on the frontline in Germany, he was arrested. He spent the next eight years in labour camps.[1] Many of Solzhenitsyn's hard-won insights and stories are still relevant to understanding the development of information networks in the twenty-first century.

One story recounts events at a district party conference in Moscow Province in the late 1930s, at the height of the Stalinist Great Terror. A call was made to pay tribute to Stalin, and the audience – who of course knew that they were being carefully watched – burst into applause. After five minutes of applause, 'palms were getting sore and raised arms were already aching. And the older people were panting from exhaustion … However, who would dare be the *first* to stop?' Solzhenitsyn explains that 'NKVD men were standing in the hall applauding and watching to see *who* quit first!' It went on and on, for six minutes, then eight, then ten. 'They couldn't stop now till they collapsed with heart attacks! … With make-believe enthusiasm on their faces, looking at each other with faint hope, the